



City of Duluth

411 West First Street
Duluth, Minnesota 55802

Minutes - Final

Library Board.

Tuesday, August 4, 2026

4:30 PM West Duluth Library Alcove, 5830 Grand Ave, Duluth, MN
55807

Call To Order

The meeting was called to order at 4:30 PM by Bill Arezzo, President

Welcome and Introductions

Present: Bill Arezzo, Carlee Bladl, Jose Gonzalez, Sarah Kessler, Lori Steinbach
Also in attendance: Library Manager Carla Powers, City Council Liaison Jordon Johnson, DPL staff members Lori Crocker and Loreen Lee
Absent: Kati Annis, Michelle Foshay, Ellen Hatfield, Sue Henke

Review and Approve Agenda

Motion by Gonzalez, seconded by Kessler, to approve agenda. Motion passed unanimously.

Approve Minutes of June 2026 Meeting

Motion by Gonzalez, seconded by Bladl, to approve minutes as drafted. Motion passed unanimously.

Public Comment

None

Reports

[LB52](#)

Library Staff Report

Loreen Lee gave the board an update on successes so far this year at the West Duluth Branch. A lot of community building is taking place through all-ages programming, opportunities for kids to learn games, intergenerational events, Tech Help at the branches (which launched in July), an escape room, and storytime programs. The branch has seen regular visits from Key Zone classes at Laura MacArthur School as well as a visit from the Boys and Girls Club. Challenges include parking for library patrons and staff, keeping up with patron demand for help with technology, and monitoring shared space in the lobby and hallway of City Center West.

[LB38](#)

Library Manager's Report August 2026

- While all positions at the library are currently filled, Powers is planning to retire toward the end of this year.
- Erin Kreeger from the Library Foundation was interviewed by a local TV station about the children's area refresh project.
- A new software platform is now in use for City of Duluth boards and commissions, to ensure that their meeting packets and minutes are ADA compliant. Library Board packets and minutes from April 2026 forward are located on the City's website and no longer available on the library's website.
- Discovery Center passes are in the works but not yet ready for checkout.

LB34

Library Usage Report June 2026

Indexes:

Attachments: [2026.06 Usage stats spreadsheet](#)

- This month's report is typical for summer. All locations have been very busy. However, the visitor count at the Main Library is somewhat lower than this time last year.
- Circulation continues to be higher this year than last year, in part because DPL is still in its first year of offering automatic renewal of items. Auto renewal started in August of 2025.
- Digital collections are still seeing an increase in demand, particularly the OverDrive/Libby collection. Use of Hoopla remains level.

LB39

Arrowhead Library System Report August 2026

- ALS is offering to provide a new PC for each affiliate public library building, which means Duluth libraries are eligible to receive three.
- The ALS Executive Director is working with State Library Services to offer public library trustee training this fall. The training may be offered online.

LB40

Friends of the Library Report August 2026

- Friends are in need of volunteers for the annual book sale, which will take place later this month.
- Liability insurance for the sale has been secured.
- Lifetime memberships were granted recently for a former Friends Board member and a longtime volunteer.
- Friends are looking for ways to share information more regularly and get members more involved in the organization.

LB41

Library Foundation Board Report August 2026

- Final phase of fundraising for the children's area refresh is underway with \$50,000 left to raise. Foundation board members and several members of the community are being invited to create their own fundraising pages using Givebutter.com with a theme of "I Was a Library Kid."

Old Business

[LB15](#) Safety Updates

Summer tends to bring fewer safety incidents. However, last month a new safety issue emerged when air quality was poor due to wildfire smoke. Although City staff shut off air intakes as soon as the smoke moved into the area, the air quality indoors degraded over time. A plan is now in place for the City of Duluth's Safety and Training Officer to test the indoor air at all three locations the next time the outdoor air reaches an unhealthy (red) level so that mitigation measures can be explored if needed.

[LB16](#) Main Library Facility/Regional Library Services District

- A resolution to formally accept the HUD grant will most likely not be on the agenda for the upcoming City Council meeting but may be ready for the meeting on August 17.
- Once the grant is accepted, an action plan must be submitted to HUD.
- After that, a steering committee will be formed and an RFP will be issued.

[LB21](#) Advocacy Update

No update this month.

New Business

[LB42](#) 2027 Library Budget

- City administration has requested status quo budget submissions for 2027. An exception may be made for contractually required increases, such as the lease for the Mount Royal Branch.
- Meetings for the upcoming budget year are expected to take place in September.

[LB43](#) City of Duluth Board and Commission Training

The City Clerk's Office sent out an online training to all City board and commission members last month. If board members have questions or cannot finish the training by the deadline, Powers offered to contact the clerk's office.

Adjournment

Motion by Gonzalez, seconded by Bladl, to adjourn the meeting. Meeting adjourned: 5:30 PM

Next Meeting: September 1, 2026, Evergreen Senior Center